



Mainland License

When registering a business on the UAE Mainland (regulated by the Department of Economic Development, or DED, in each respective emirate), you have several legal structures to choose from.

The structure you select determines your liability, the number of shareholders allowed, and whether you need a local service agent.

1. Limited Liability Company (LLC)

This is by far the most popular structure for trading, commercial, and industrial operations on the mainland.

- Shareholders: Min. 1, Max. 50 (can be individual or corporate).
- Liability: Limited. Your personal assets are protected; you are only liable up to the extent of your shares in the company.
- Ownership: Following recent updates to the Commercial Companies Law, 100% foreign ownership is permitted for most commercial and industrial activities.
- Best for: General trading, e-commerce, logistics, construction, and manufacturing.

2. Sole Establishment (Sole Proprietorship)

A company owned and run completely by one individual.

- Shareholders: Exactly 1 person.
- Liability: Unlimited. There is no legal distinction between your personal assets and the business. If the business defaults, you are personally responsible for the debt.
- Ownership & Agent: Expats can own 100% of a sole establishment for professional or service-based activities, a Local Service Agent (LSA) is generally appointed—a UAE National who handles government relations for a fixed fee but holds 0% equity.
- Best for: Consultants, freelancers, tech specialists, and small service-based businesses.

3. Civil Company (Civil Partnership)

A structure specifically designed for professionals who want to pool their skills and operate as partners.

- Shareholders: Two or more individuals.
- Liability: Unlimited. Partners are personally liable for the debts and obligations of the firm.
- Ownership: 100% foreign ownership is allowed for expats. However, like the Sole Establishment, a Local Service Agent (LSA) who is a UAE national is generally appointed.
- Best for: Doctors, lawyers, accountants, engineers, and digital marketers.

4. Branch or Representative Office

For an existing company (local or foreign) looking to expand its presence onto the UAE mainland.

- Branch Office: Can conduct business, execute contracts, and generate revenue, but its activities must match the parent company.
- Representative Office: Strictly for marketing and promotional activities. It cannot trade, sign contracts, or turn a profit in the UAE.
- Liability: The parent company bears 100% of the liability.

5. Private Joint Stock Company (PrJSC) / Public Joint Stock Company (PJSC)

These are larger corporate structures intended for massive enterprises, financial institutions, or companies intending to go public.

- Private (PrJSC): Formed by a minimum of 3 founders. The shares cannot be offered to the public.
- Public (PJSC): Formed by a minimum of 10 founders (except when a government entity is involved). Shares are openly traded on a stock exchange like the DFM or ADX, and a minimum capital threshold applies.